“We decided that we had to take revenge for what they did. Both of us were saying, ‘let’s get revenge.’ I said my blood was boiling, and he said his blood was boiling, and the whole country was silent, and we were wondering, ‘why did they do this to them, and what were they guilty of?’”

They spent two nights searching for the right victim. On the first, they assaulted a Palestinian woman pushing her young child in a stroller, who quickly fled. “We said she shouldn’t bring any more children into the world,” Ben-David recalled. They found Abu Khdair the following night, after the second minor joined their group. (The names of both accomplices were sealed by the court because of their ages.)

Abu Khdair’s slaying appalled the vast majority of Israelis, and was roundly condemned by the entire political class. “The murder of your son is abhorrent and cannot be countenanced by any human being,” Netanyahu told the boy’s father, Hussein, several days later. Elyakim Levanon, a hardline rabbi affiliated with the settler movement (who once threatened to “cut off” Netanyahu’s hand if he tried to dismantle an illegal outpost), called for Abu Khdair’s killers to face the death penalty, which has not been applied in Israel since the Nazi leader Adolf Eichmann was executed in 1962. The police moved swiftly, and within four days the suspects were apprehended. The case was over—an outlier, everyone swiftly agreed. There was unequivocal condemnation in the pages of *Israel HaYom*, the country’s most widely-read newspaper:

> We are commanded to throw up from within us, and also to condemn, the tiny minority that, as was published yesterday, is suspected of murdering and burning to death the Arab boy. We are compelled to ask and cry aloud the words of the prophet Ezekiel, “You shed blood; shall you then possess the land?”[16]

So too in *Arutz Sheva*, a website popular with the settler movement: “No one in the state of Israel believed in committing murder in such horrific circumstances… the value of human dignity and the sanctity of life, they are the basis of Jewish ethics.”[17]

The killers were similar to Yigal Amir, pundits argued, the extremist who assassinated Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin in 1995. They acted alone, and their actions were unconnected to the prevailing political climate in the country. “There is this pernicious belief that half the country assassinated Rabin,” one acquaintance complained. “And now it’s going to rear its head again.”